

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

6-1 (A)

Rcd 12/8/00 wpl

NEW STATE RECORD _____ UNUSUAL RECORD _____

Species: Lesser Black-backed Gull (*Larus fuscus graellsii*)**Date:** 12 November 2000**Number seen:** one**Sex:** ?**Plumage:** Def. Basic**Locality:** Cherry Creek Res.**Elevation:** about 5350'**Nearest town:** Aurora**County:** Arapahoe**Time observed:** about 10:30-10:45 MST**Duration of observation:** about 15 minutes in all

Description: I was birding with Michael Patten and Larry Semo at Cherry Creek Res. when we ran into Joey Kellner and Andy Spencer. They said that they had just seen two adult Lesser Black-backed Gulls (LBBG) at the southeast corner of the reservoir. Upon our arrival at that spot, we quickly found both birds. I could just see part of one leg on one bird that was lying down and that part was pink. Since pink legs on adult LBBGs is rare, I figured it for the bird I had seen on 15 October and documented separately. The other bird was a different individual and I document it here. Except for leg color and minor differences in head streaking, the two birds were nearly identical.

The bird was slightly bigger and much darker-mantled than the nearby CAGUs (but nowhere near as dark as a Great Black-backed Gull would have been) and was smaller than a nearby Herring Gull (HERG). The head was fairly angular unlike that of the CAGUs. The streaking on the head was fairly extensive and coalesced around the eyes into darker patches. The bill was yellow with a large, red gonydeal spot, and with a fairly strong gonydeal angle. The eyes were yellow, as were the legs. The underparts were white, but the chest had brown mottling. The bird had thin, white tertial and scapular crescents. The wingtips extended considerably beyond the tail tip, with at least primary tips visible beyond the tail tip.

Similar species eliminated: California Gull (CAGU) eliminated by size, mantle color, and bill size and shape. HERG (*smithsonianus*) ruled out by mantle color and leg color. Other, darker forms of HERG ruled out by size (they should be larger). Slaty-backed Gull (SBGU) eliminated by wing pattern (number of mirrors and color of secondaries, the visible parts of which should be mostly white), mantle color (the bird was not virtually black-backed), and leg color. Kelp Gull (KEGU) ruled out by bill (size and shape) and by mantle color. Great Black-backed Gull eliminated by size and by upperparts color and pattern, and by leg color.

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration): No vocalizations heard.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly-appearing species? I have seen >85 *graellsii* LBBGs on the Great Lakes and the East Coast and >10 previously in CO, bazillions of *smithsonianus* HERGs, >125 *vegae* HERGs, 10s of 1000s of GBBGs, 1000s of CAGUs, and >75 SBGUs. I have not seen any other of the darker, Asian HERGs, nor have I seen KEGU.

Light conditions: sun was to my left

Optical equipment used: Leica 32x and Swarovski 8x42

Distance, and how estimated: estimated closest distance at about 100 meters

Other observers who saw the bird with you: Larry Semo and Michael Patten (11/12)

Other observers who saw the bird independently: Joey Kellner and Andy Spencer

If photographed, type of equipment and film: I did not photograph the bird.

List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: none

b) after observation: none

Reporting observer: Tony Leukering

Signature:

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read "Tony Leukering", with a stylized flourish at the end.

Address: Colorado Bird Observatory, 13401 Picadilly Road, Brighton, CO 80601

Date report was written: 5 December 2000 from memory